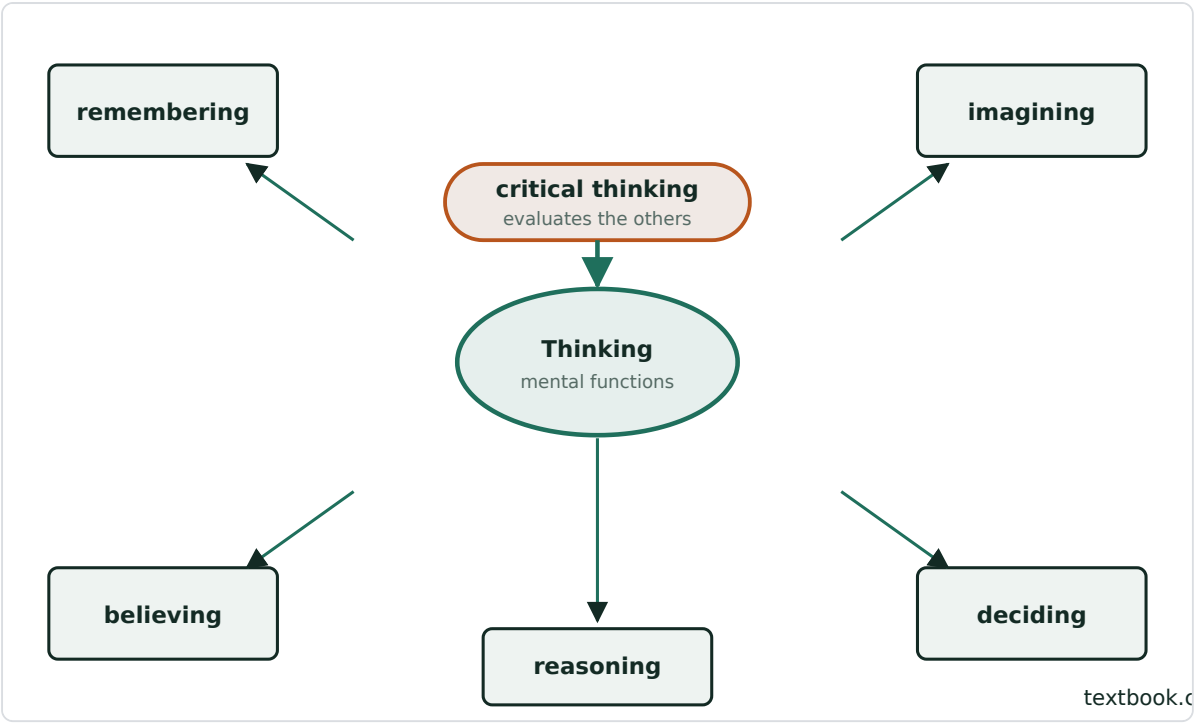
Draft - expert review pending

Note: This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but it is not reviewed yet. So, treat its sources and claims with care. You are encouraged to report errors and provide feedback.

Topic 1.1 - What thinking is, and what makes it critical

A real classroom situation

A teacher in a government primary school in interior Sindh is told at a staff meeting that her results would improve if she "made the pupils think more". She is not sure what that means. She already asks questions, she sets written work, and she walks around the room while the class works. When she pictures "thinking", she imagines a quiet child staring at a sums page. She wonders what she is supposed to do differently - and whether the problem is her teaching or her pupils' ability.



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Critical thinking IS	Critical thinking is NOT
what it does	finding fault with people judges reasoning against clear standards
how it decides what it needs **who it is** **classroom marker**	applies clarity, accuracy, relevance, depth, logic a piece of reasoning to examine a skill that can be trained "what is the evidence, and does it support that?"
a hook	short opening question sets up the topic

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Her uncertainty is common, and it matters. Without a clear picture of what thinking is and what makes it *critical*, the instruction to "make them think" is too vague to act on. This topic gives you that picture.

Explanation

Thinking as a skill that can be trained

Thinking is not a single thing the mind does. Thinking covers a range of functions: remembering a fact, imagining a possibility, believing a claim, deciding between options, and reasoning from evidence to a conclusion (Bassham, Irwin, Nardone & Wallace, 2010). These functions are not fixed abilities you are born with. Like any skill, they improve with practice and with being shown how. A pupil who is asked only to copy from the board is exercising memory; a pupil who is asked to compare two answers and decide which is better is exercising reasoning. The difference is in the demand the task makes, not in the pupil.

The various functions of thought

Bassham et al. (2010) group the functions of thought into two broad kinds: *taking in* (perceiving, remembering, believing) and *working on* (reasoning, deciding, judging). Critical thinking belongs to the second kind. It is the function that steps back from what you have taken in and asks, "Is this belief well supported? Does this conclusion follow from the reasons given?" You use it when you evaluate a newspaper claim, decide whether a new teaching method is worth trying, or judge whether a pupil's wrong answer reveals a careless mistake or a genuine misconception.

What critical thinking is, and what it is not

Here is the distinction many introductory treatments blur, and it is the heart of this unit: **critical thinking is a set of standards applied to a piece of reasoning, not a personality trait and not a habit of doubting everything.**

- It is **not** the same as "criticising" in the everyday sense of finding fault. A person who dismisses every new idea is not thinking critically; they

are being dismissive. Critical thinking judges reasoning on its merits, whether the conclusion turns out to be right or wrong.

- It is **not** general scepticism. Refusing to accept anything without proof is a stance, not a skill. Critical thinking accepts well-supported claims and challenges weak ones.
- It **is** the habit of asking of any piece of reasoning: Is it clear? Is it accurate? Is it relevant? Is it deep enough for the question at stake? Those questions are the *standards*, and the next topic examines them in detail.

A useful way to hold the distinction is as a contrast pair: two teachers hear a workshop claim that a new method "raises results by 30 per cent". The first teacher accepts it because the speaker sounded confident. The second asks, "Thirty per cent of what, measured how, compared with what?" The second teacher is not being difficult; they are applying a standard. That is critical thinking in action.

> **Common misconception.** Many trainees arrive with the idea that "being intelligent and thinking critically are the same thing". They are not. A person of high intelligence can hold a poorly supported belief and defend it cleverly. Critical thinking is a *practice* - a set of moves you make when you judge reasoning - and it can be learned and improved regardless of how "naturally clever" you are.

> ## Activity: What would have to be true?
>
> Work in pairs. About 20 minutes.
>
> Take the staffroom claim: **"This class cannot do word problems."** For each of the four questions below, write one sentence saying what would have to be true for the claim to stand up.

1. Is it *clear* - do we know what "cannot do" means and what kind of word problems are meant?
2. Is it *accurate* - what evidence shows the whole class fails at this?
3. Is it *relevant* - is the problem the pupils' ability, the way the problems are written, or the teaching they have had?
4. Is it *deep* - does the claim explain *why* they struggle, or only report that they do?

Compare your sentences with another pair. Where you disagree, explain your reasoning.

Check your understanding

1. **Remember** In your own words, name two functions of thought that are *not* critical thinking and one that is.

2. **Understand** Explain the difference between critical thinking and general scepticism in one or two sentences.

3. **Apply** A colleague says, "Critical people just complain all the time." Using the is/is-not distinction from this topic, give two reasons that statement confuses critical thinking with something else.

Summary

Thinking is a set of functions, not a single ability. Critical thinking is the function that judges reasoning against standards. It is a skill that can be trained, not a personality you have or lack, and it is not the

> same as criticising or doubting everything. The standards it applies are the subject of the next topic.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can explain what critical thinking is in a way that distinguishes it from merely criticising.
- ☐ I can give an example of a classroom moment that shows critical thinking and one that does not.
- ☐ I can name at least two functions of thought that are not critical thinking.

Try this at your practicum school

At your next staff meeting or team conversation, listen for one claim about pupils or teaching (for example, "these children cannot read" or "that method never works here"). Write it down. Then write one sentence for each of these: what would have to be true for the claim to be *clear*, *accurate*, *relevant*, and *deep*? Bring your notes to the next session.

Summative task

Take the claim **"Homework does not improve learning in primary school."** Write a short paragraph (80-120 words) evaluating it against *two* of the four standards introduced in this activity (clarity, accuracy,

relevance, depth). For each standard, state whether the claim meets it and give one piece of reasoning for your judgement.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	Levels
Standards identified	0-2: names two standards and uses them correctly / names one / none.
Evidence used	0-3: gives specific reasoning for each judgement / vague or generic reasoning / none. (**Analyze**: cites a concrete reason the claim does or does not meet the standard.)
Clarity	0-2: paragraph is coherent and within the word band / unclear or over length.

Further reading

Bassham, G., Irwin, W., Nardone, H., & Wallace, J. M. (2010). *Critical thinking: A student's introduction* (4th ed.). McGraw-Hill. Chapters 1-2 introduce the nature of critical thinking and the is/is-not distinctions drawn in this topic.

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